The High-Definition Itch

You might not be able to afford one. There is nothing to watch on one. But you still want one. We help you scratch that HDTV itch

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There is no clear path to HD land. The idea of high-definition television is a beehive of activity with new tech replacing the old, faster than a speeding bullet. With no clear winner, choices are numerous, with many pros and cons to weigh. Things are not very clear on the content either: HD content producers are ambiguous on their DRM (Digital Rights Management) policies—will they, won't they, and when (because they will)? What resolution will be widely adopted, to what extent will DRM shackle our media? To make matters worse, the content sources are anaemic in India (neither over-the-air nor broadcast HD channels available); the only HD content currently on offer being games. Nor is there any clarity on the next-generation of HD media—will Blu-Ray best HD-DVD or vice-versa?

But walk into an electronics shop and your jaw drops—pretty HDTVs all in a row and none of the above matters, lust overtakes logic; and while some practical corner of your brain pleads to look before you leap into the HD stream, you can't help but scratch that big-screen itch.

So, hearts filled with joyful consumerism, let's take a walk through the HD swamp—learn a bit about what makes an HDTV, and take a look at some of the numerous technologies available, with a strong emphasis on the pros and cons of each. Which technology to pick? There is no clear answer. Consider this an interesting journey without a destination.

What Makes An HDTV?

All televisions display images as a grid of coloured dots or pixels. The more the dots a TV can display, the higher its resolution. The TV sets that most of us currently use is called SDTV; it has the lowest resolution possible. An enhanced version of this type of TV—called EDTV—is also available, but even that type does not differ much over the SD variety. The drawback of a low resolution is that as the screen size of a television set increases, the TV has to fit the same number of pixels to a larger screen area. This results in poor image quality; it's similar to watching a video recorded by a cell phone on a PC in full-screen mode. Larger displays offer a more cinematic experience. This is where HDTV steps in.

TVs generally come in two screen ratios—a 4:3 screen and a 16:9 screen; some sets also sport

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